described as having killed many more brothers in his bid to capture the throne of Magadha. The *Dipavamsa* says a hundred brothers were so killed.[33] Figures such as this, as we have seen, are a common stereotype, merely a way of saying that many brothers were killed, not just one, as the *Mahavamsa* would have us believe. Killing off his brothers may well have allowed Ashoka to rule, but it is possible that protracted fratricidal battles had first to be waged, for the *Dipavamsa* suggests a gap of four years between that bloody assumption and Ashoka's formal consecration as emperor.[34]

A far more gory and viscera-filled tale is told of Ashoka's accession in the *Ashokavadana*, where certain kingmakers, rather than Ashoka, are ministers and key figures in the court of Bindusara. The decision to ensure that Bindusara's eldest son would not succeed him is traced back in this text to a slight that the king's prime minister suffered at the hands of Susima, the heir apparent. It seems the prince slapped the bald head of the minister in jest. The minister, however, was not amused and formed a coalition hostile to the 'jester'. The turn of events is described:

> 'Today he slaps me with his hand,' the minister reflected, 'when he becomes king he'll let fall his sword! I had better take action now to ensure that he does not inherit the throne.'
>
> He therefore sought to alienate five hundred ministers from Susima, saying to them: 'It has been predicted that Ashoka will become chakravartin ruler over one of the four continents. When the time comes, let us place him on the throne.'[35]

Soon after this, the people of Taxila again rose in rebellion. This time, instead of Ashoka, Susima was sent by the king to quell it. Almost immediately thereafter, Bindusara is said to have fallen seriously ill. He recalled Susima, intending to consecrate him as his successor, and ordered that Ashoka be sent to Taxila in his place. But the coalition of ministers pretended that Ashoka was ill. On his deathbed, in fact, they urged Bindusara to instal Ashoka as his successor for the moment and replace him with Susima upon the latter's return.